

easier to talk about as they're referred to by names. For example, it's much easier to ask (and answer) "Will Alice be attracted by a red background?" than "Will a red background be attractive to our end users?"

A persona, as a deliverable, is typically a character profile, which includes a name, age, profession and lifestyle, i.e. specific habits, frequently performed tasks, daily routine and other such key attributes that affect the usage of the product or service.

Persona-fication

Do your research

There's only one way to gather these facts, and that is to go out and collect them. User research is the crux of persona creation. While there are many ways to go about getting the data, sadly, there are no shortcuts.

Research methods

While there are many research methods, the utility of the information ultimately depends on the quality of questions and number of people asked (as many as possible). We can never stress enough on research. (So we won't. Studious children never result from nagging parents.) Here are a few techniques for obtaining the raw material for your personas:

- ◆ **Surveys:** Surveys involve form-type questionnaires that are filled out by carefully selected individuals.
- ◆ **Ethnographic Field Studies:** This involves studying relevant participants in their environment, where they would naturally come across or use the product or service.
- ◆ **Contextual Inquiries:** This is a cross between interviews and field studies, where you can either simulate the context or ask the participants to imagine them, after which you either ask questions (subjective data) or ask them to perform a task (objective data).
- ◆ **Web Analytics:** You could find a lot of answers to your questions – right from usage trends such as the number of Google searches for a certain keyword and the frequency of such terms to web trends.
- ◆ **Focus Groups:** A few (3-15) participants are led through a discussion and/or exercises, while they give written or verbal feedback.

Creating a Persona

Once you've done your homework (see previous sub-section), and done it well, you need to pull a persona out of it, like pulling a silicon crystal